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THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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Last week: **DJIA** 51770.31 ▼ 444.85 0.85% **NASDAQ** 25437.00 ▼ 2.0% **STOXX 600** 646.75 ▲ 1.7% **10-YR. TREASURY** ▲ 15/32, yield 4.928% **OIL** $104.12 ▲ $0.85 **EURO** $1.1160 **YEN** 157.57

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Some investors who** have successfully ridden the AI boom are now sizing up how to protect themselves against the risk of the trade unraveling. **A1**

◆ **OpenAI has raised** less than half of the $30 billion it had initially targeted for its latest funding round amid recent stock jitters. **B1**

◆ **Lenders and investors** are becoming choosier about where to place their bets in the AI sector, demanding tougher terms from the firms. **B1**

◆ **More women are** breaking into what has been a boys' club of skilled trades, drawn by well-paying jobs that are in high demand. **A1**

◆ **Meta's Muse** AI agent is a growing nuisance for Amazon, bypassing human interaction on the e-commerce site and threatening its ad business. **B1**

◆ **The speed and scale** of the $6.3 billion Binance heist have left the cryptocurrency industry reeling, renewing questions about the safety of storing digital assets. **B1**

◆ **A fund run by Ares** Management is buying the $2.5 billion fund MFIC from one of its largest competitors, Apollo Global Management. **B3**

◆ **After years of consumer** complaints about overcharging, Dollar Tree's pricing is drawing scrutiny from the Federal Trade Commission. **B1**

◆ **Prediction market** companies, which make confident claims about their accuracy on elections, have been plagued by recent misses. **A4**

◆ **Buyout firm TPG** is heading toward a record year in fundraising, lifting its full-year target to more than $55 billion. **B3**

Worldwide

◆ **Democratic Party** infighting flared in Michigan as Rep. Haley Stevens endorsed GOP candidate Mike Rogers for Senate over Abdul El-Sayed, who had defeated her in the primary. **A1**

◆ **The administration's** bid to block Alaska from certifying its election if the Republican Senate candidate loses was denied in federal court. **A5**

◆ **The U.S. is backing** a quick resumption of Russian natural-gas sales to Europe via pipelines running through Ukraine as part of talks aimed at an energy ceasefire. **A1**

◆ **Sen. Chris Murphy** of Connecticut, 53, a Democrat considered to be one of the party's stars, suffered a stroke. He was reported to be making progress. **A2**

◆ **A Learjet carrying** nine people crashed near a busy road in South Florida, killing everyone onboard. **A3**

◆ **Europe's stretched** finances and an aging population are threatening the model of a cradle-to-grave welfare state and stoking the public's anger. **A7**

◆ **Churches are increasingly** using their properties to build affordable housing, a trend known as YIGBY, or Yes in God's Backyard. **A3**

◆ **A federal judge** dismissed Trump's defamation lawsuit over The Wall Street Journal's article about his birthday note to Jeffrey Epstein. **A4**

◆ **Somali pirates** seized an Iranian fishing vessel carrying 23 people, and authorities warned it could be used as a mother ship to attack other targets. **A7**

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JOSE JUAREZ/AP

Democrat Haley Stevens and GOP Senate candidate Mike Rogers were all smiles on Sunday at a Detroit church as she endorsed the Republican over Abdul El-Sayed, the Democrat who had beaten her in the Michigan primary earlier this year.

Democratic Infighting Flares Ahead of Key Senate Election

Michigan primary loser's backing of Republican lays bare party finger-pointing

By Eliza Collins And Sabrina Rodriguez

Democrats have a chance to retake the Senate on Tuesday—a proposition that seemed far-fetched earlier this year. But instead of unifying ahead of Election Day, the party is already engaged in infighting and finger-pointing.

Allies of the party's leaders privately say that an insurgent left wing has unnecessarily sucked time and money into races that should have been easier for Democrats, to the detriment of other candidates. Progressives say the party's establishment isn't doing everything possible to help them win, according to people familiar with the conversations.

Tensions spilled out publicly Sunday when a Democratic congresswoman in Michigan who lost this year's Senate primary to Abdul El-Sayed endorsed the Republican nominee in the close-fought race. Rep. Haley Stevens, who had been the party leadership's pick in the primary against the more progressive El-Sayed, said Sunday she was backing former GOP Rep. Mike Rogers after previously endorsing El-Sayed.

The Democratic rivals' clash has centered on Stevens's disapproval of El Sayed's critical comments about Israel's actions in the Middle East.

In response, Democrats on Sunday rallied around their nominee and criticized Stevens, with Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D., N.Y.) calling it a "despicable betrayal" in a statement in which he also condemned an increase in anti-Muslim attacks against El-Sayed by Republicans in the final weeks of the campaign.

But the spat, just days before the election, is the latest example of Democratic division. Both factions want a Democratic Senate, and winning may soothe the acrimony. But whatever the outcome, Tuesday's results are poised to accelerate an internecine battle for the future of the party. If the Democrats fall short in the Senate, each side will blame the other. If they are victorious, each side will claim the credit and declare its vision vindicated.

If El-Sayed, a former public health official, pulls off a win in Michigan, it will bolster an argument the far-left is already making: Their candidates can win hard races in purple states. That mindset belies a long-held belief among top Democrats that only mod-

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Investors Seeking Insurance To Cover AI Bets

Traders, tech bosses set hedging plays as booming market grows more volatile

By Gunjan Banerji

Wall Street placed a multitrillion-dollar bet on artificial intelligence. Some investors are desperate to take the other side.

Excitement about AI's potential to transform the economy has lifted stocks from tech heavyweights to utilities and chip makers, while driving a speculative frenzy in other corners of the market. Some of these optimistic forecasts got a recent reality check, with big and small players alike failing to meet the market's expectations. Now, investors are sizing up how to protect themselves against the risk of a larger unraveling.

"We're seeing really significant demand from folks looking to protect downside," said Stephen Solaka, a senior vice president at Gateway Investment Advisers.

The jitters are starting to show up in a number of ways: the yields lenders demand to finance big data-center projects and chip purchases; the plunging stock and bond prices of some AI "neocloud" companies such as CoreWeave that are borrowing heavily; and steep selloffs from tech darlings including Alphabet and Intel, which just recorded some of their biggest one-day drops ever. The tech-heavy

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◆ **Investors, lenders get pickier about AI bets..... B1**

◆ **OpenAI raises less than half of funding target.....B1**

Firms Weld Labor Gap In Trades By Hiring Women

By Te-Ping Chen

Sammy Cossairt has tried call center work, waiting tables and hoisting concrete. She prefers hoisting concrete.

The 36-year-old tower crane operator in Nashville, Tenn., who works 12-hour shifts, helps lift and move rebar and buckets of concrete from a perch often hundreds of feet in the air. This isn't what she envisioned when she received a liberal arts associate degree more than a decade ago, but after nearly 10 years on the job, she feels at home in her crane.

"I'm out in the sun, making my mark on the world," said Cossairt, who makes $120,000 a year. "I think more women would love to get in and make men's money doing this work, if they only knew."

The skilled trades have long been a boys' club. But more women are breaking in, drawn by well-paying jobs that are in high demand. To keep them coming, many companies are courting women like Cossairt through new benefits and perks, including paid maternity leave and more flexibility. They are also trying to create a more welcoming work environment while cracking down on off-color jokes and catcalls on male-dominated jobsites.

The federal government tracks female participation in fields such as construction, and installation and repair, which includes jobs such as plumbers, carpenters and auto

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
A couple faces tough choices picking a health plan during open enrollment. **A11**



CALEB BOWLIN/GETTY IMAGES

SPORTS
A first-time entrant from Sweden wins the New York City Marathon. **A14**

Running a Shoestring Campaign Brings a Multitude of Indignities

* * *

In a $12 billion midterm election cycle, one candidate pawned tools to stay in it

By Joshua Chaffin And Anthony DeBarros

BOWLING GREEN, Ky.—Megan Wingfield apologized to the gas station clerk as she labored to unpeel and count the thin stack of bills. The tally, when it eventually arrived, was $23—good for half a tank for her 2013 Jeep to get her to that evening's campaign event.

For Wingfield, 32, a Democrat and first-time candidate, that small indignity was but one of many in a threadbare campaign she is running against a well-funded incumbent in Kentucky's Second congressional district. She recently pawned her power tools "to make ends meet."

Her campaign headquarters, a nook in the one-bedroom apartment she shares with two dogs and a cat, features the usual ringlight for recording social-media videos and a laptop propped on a raccoon trap.

"We've had to be resourceful," said Wingfield, wedged into a camping chair. "When you talk about a shoestring budget—that pretty much hits the nail on the head."

This midterm cycle is the most expensive in history, with candidates and their backers spending nearly $12 billion, according to ad-tracking firm AdImpact.

Then there are candidates like Wingfield, who have somehow managed to stay dry amid a deluge of dollars. Most don't

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U.S. Urges Restart Of Russia Gas Sales

The U.S. is backing a quick resumption of Russian natural-gas sales to Europe via pipelines running through Moscow's wartime enemy—

*By **Yaroslav Trofimov**, **Drew Hinshaw** and **Joe Parkinson***

Ukraine—as part of negotiations aimed at securing an energy ceasefire ahead of the coming winter, U.S., European and Ukrainian officials said.

The idea, broached by U.S. envoys Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff during trips to Moscow and Kyiv in September, would involve selling Russian gas via a U.S. intermediary to circumvent European sanctions—and could create a lucrative opportunity for American investors, people who attended the discussions said.

Under current European Union legislation, all purchases of Russian natural gas must be phased out by the end of 2027. Leaders of Europe's biggest nations have said they have no interest in restoring their dependence on energy supplies from a nation they view as their top strategic threat.

The plan was put on the back burner last month after Ukraine unilaterally stopped

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Easy Money Traps Small Businesses

Merchant cash advances deliver quick funding, but at high effective costs

By Ruth Simon And Neil Mehta

Opportunity came knocking at the door of Triways, a family owned trucking and warehouse business in Southern California that had successfully navigated the ups and downs of nearly a half-century of hauling goods.

Triways earned industry awards, employed some 60 workers and took in nearly $10 million in revenue in 2024. After struggling through a postpandemic slowdown, the company got an offer that year to serve Navy commissaries in California, Oregon, Washington and Florida.

"I wasn't trying to grow, but the opportunity was put on the table," said John Jauregui, the 70-year-old chief executive. It would require more truck trailers and more drivers, a significant upfront expense, he said. But it was a chance to transform the Jurupa Valley, Calif., company into a nationwide operation.

Getting the money was easy. Jauregui turned to merchant cash advances—MCAs for short—a legal, largely unregulated financing industry marketed on social media as a business lifeline: Cash in 24

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